reached in 1886, after much negotiation, for a Government of India subsidy worth Rs 15,000 for a coasting line between Tuticorin and Colombo.[39]

But the line did not stabilize until the 1890s. Responding to a telegram from the managing agents of the company in late December 1894 about the probable number of 'coolie passengers' on thrice-weekly trips, Alstons Scott and Company, the then Colombo Agents of BI, replied that between seventy-five and hundred passengers travelled per trip.[40] Despite constraints of irregularity of service, 'we think the above number could be reckoned upon with certainty and as during the next few years (when the tea estates will be coming into being) a large and increasing force of coolies will be required in Ceylon from India, and in consequence, a corresponding number will be returning thereto, a regular service such as that proposed would without doubt secure all the traffic.' However, they sounded a note of caution. The great advantage of taking a BI steamer was its size and the consequent comfort; but if only a small steamer was pressed into service, the labourers would prefer 'the old route via the North Road to Jaffna'.[41] A few days later, they prepared a memo of passengers who sailed on the company's line and calculated that a total of 13,679 had sailed in the past year, giving a weekly average of 263. Replacing the schooners (a sailing ship with two masts) with steamships was proposed and the Agents reckoned that with regular service the number of first-class passengers would also rise. Regularity was the key. 'A great majority of the passengers come from country districts and endeavour to arrive on the day of the steamer sailing so as to avoid the expensive living in town.' In a foretaste of the bitter rate war during the Swadeshi movement, the Colombo Agents, while providing a comparative memo of steamer and schooner fares, suggested helpfully, 'no doubt you will agree to *lower the rates* for a time in order to encourage traffic and *cut out the Schooners*.'[42]

In 1894, BI's daily service (excepting Sundays) between Tuticorin and Colombo was inaugurated.[43] By the turn of the century, BI steamers sailed on Sundays as well, even as its regular coasting steamers also called at Tuticorin once a week from Bombay and Calcutta.[44] As BI prospered, the